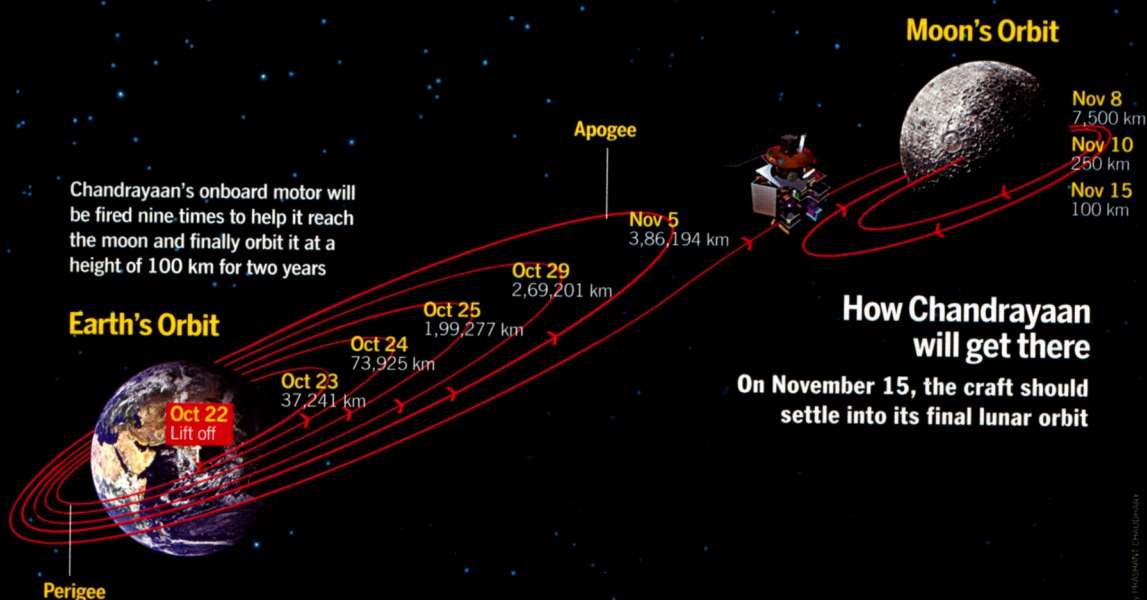


India's On Shot



Chandrayaan's onboard motor will be fired nine times to help it reach the moon and finally orbit it at a height of 100 km for two years

Earth's Orbit

Moon's Orbit

How Chandrayaan will get there

On November 15, the craft should settle into its final lunar orbit

■ By Raj Chengappa in Sriharikota

With its lunar mission blasting off, India takes a giant step towards planetary exploration and even manned space flights

There could've been no better Diwali gift for Indians. At Rs 400 crore a pop, it is probably the costliest rocket ever sent up to celebrate the coming of the festival. Even the intermittent rain couldn't dampen the launch preparations. Precisely on schedule at 6.22 am on October 22, the Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle, PSLV-C 11, carrying India's most prestigious space payload to date, Chandrayaan-1, lifted off with a burst of orange fumes from the launchpad in Sriharikota in Andhra Pradesh.

The launcher blazed across the firmament like a comet and was soon enveloped by the cloudy skies briefly reappearing before being swallowed up again. Seconds later, the sonic boom caused in its wake shook the buildings in the space port. No rock music band can ever hope to match the bass roar of its rockets as it powered the vehicle into orbit. The space launch was probably the best sound and light show, albeit the briefest. Inside the Master Control Centre, Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) scientists sat tensely watching the giant screens and computer consoles flashing information of the